

GUIDE 3 OF 4

Prep Kit

South Jersey Edition · Camden · Gloucester · Burlington Counties

Everything you need to challenge your property tax assessment.

How to read your assessment notice · Calculate if you're over-assessed

Build your comparables case · Navigate the Tax Board hearing

Includes a fillable worksheet to determine your appeal strength.

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This guide is for informational purposes only. It does not constitute legal or tax advice. Program rules, deadlines, and benefit amounts change annually. Always verify current information at nj.gov or by calling 1-888-238-1233 before filing.

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Do You Have a Case?

The math every homeowner should run before April 1

Most NJ homeowners never appeal their property taxes — not because their assessments are correct, but because the process feels intimidating. In reality, the appeal process is straightforward for residential properties, and the potential savings are permanent. A \$50,000 reduction in assessed value at a 2.8% tax rate saves **\$1,400 every year going forward** — not just once.

The Fundamental Test

The core question in any property tax appeal is: **Is your implied market value higher than what your home would actually sell for today?**

$$\text{Implied Market Value} = \text{Assessed Value} \div \text{Equalization Ratio}$$

If your Implied Market Value is significantly higher than what comparable homes in your neighborhood have actually sold for, you are over-assessed and have grounds for an appeal.

Example Calculation

Your Example		Sample Home
Assessed Value	(from your tax bill)	\$280,000
Equalization Ratio	(from NJ equalization table)	87%
Implied Market Value	Assessed $\div$ Ratio	\$321,839
Recent Comparable Sales	(from MLS data)	\$295,000 avg
Potential Over-Assessment	Implied minus Comps	\$26,839
Potential Annual Savings	Overassessment $\times$ Tax Rate (2.8%)	\$751/year

2 Your Personal Appeal Worksheet

Complete this worksheet to determine your appeal strength before filing. Keep this document — you will reference it throughout the process.

A	Assessed Value (from your tax bill)	\$ _____
B	Equalization Ratio (from NJ equalization table at nj.gov)	_____ %
C	Implied Market Value ($A \div B$)	\$ _____
D	Comp 1: Address & Sale Price	\$ _____
E	Comp 2: Address & Sale Price	\$ _____
F	Comp 3: Address & Sale Price	\$ _____
G	Average of Comps D, E, F	\$ _____
H	Over-Assessment (C minus G, if positive)	\$ _____
I	Your Tax Rate (from tax bill)	_____ %
J	Estimated Annual Savings ($H \times I$)	\$ _____
K	County Filing Fee	\$ _____
L	Net First-Year Savings (J minus K)	\$ _____

Rule of thumb: If Line J shows savings of \$300+ per year, an appeal is almost always worth filing. The filing fee is typically \$25-50. The savings are permanent.

3 How to Find Your Comparables

Comparable sales ("comps") are your most powerful evidence. The Tax Board evaluates your home against what similar homes actually sold for — not what Zillow says or what your neighbor thinks. Real MLS data is significantly more persuasive than any estimate.

What Makes a Good Comparable

Location	Same neighborhood or street if possible. Within 1-2 miles maximum for suburban areas. Must be in the same municipality for the most weight.
Sale Date	Within 12 months of October 1 of the tax year being appealed. More recent is better. Sales from 2-3 years ago carry less weight.
Square Footage	Within 15-20% of your home's size. A 1,800 sq ft home should use comps between 1,500 and 2,100 sq ft.
Bed/Bath Count	Same or very similar bedroom and bathroom count. Adjustments can be made but identical counts are stronger.
Condition	Similar overall condition. If your home needs work, note this explicitly. A distressed sale comp can actually support a lower valuation.
Lot Size	Similar lot size for single-family homes. Less critical for condos.

Free Comparable Report

John Scafide can pull MLS comparable sales for your specific property at no cost. This is the same data the Tax Board reviews. Request yours at NJPropertyTaxRelief.com.

4 Filing Your Appeal — Step by Step

Step 1	Calculate Your Case	Feb–Mar	Complete the worksheet in Section 2. If Line J shows \$300+ in annual savings, proceed to Step 2.
Step 2	Request Your Comp Report	Feb–Mar	Contact NJPropertyTaxRelief.com for a free MLS comp report, or research sales at your county's tax records website. Find at least 3 strong comparables.
Step 3	Obtain the Appeal Form	Feb–Mar	Download from your County Board of Taxation website or call to request one. Camden: (856) 225-5238 · Gloucester: (856) 853-3440 · Burlington: (609) 265-5327
Step 4	Complete the Form	Mar	Fill in your property information, assessed value, your opinion of value (what you believe your home is worth), and attach your comparable sales.
Step 5	File Before April 1	By Apr 1	File in person or by mail with your filing fee (typically \$25-50 check payable to the County Board). Keep a copy of everything. Get a receipt or mail certified.
Step 6	Attend Your Hearing	Apr–Aug	You will receive a hearing date by mail. Bring your comps, your worksheet, and your completed form. Dress professionally. Be factual, not emotional.
Step 7	Review the Decision	Varies	The Board will issue a written decision. If successful, your assessed value is reduced going forward. If denied, you may appeal to NJ Tax Court.

5 What to Say at the Hearing

Tax Board hearings are informal but professional. A South Jersey residential hearing typically lasts 5-15 minutes. The Board member will review your comparables and ask questions. Here is a script to guide you:

Opening	<i>"My name is [Name] and I own the property at [Address]. I am appealing my assessment of \$[Amount] for tax year [Year]."</i>
Present Your Evidence	<i>"I have three comparable sales in my neighborhood from the past 12 months. [Sale 1], [Sale 2], and [Sale 3] sold for an average of \$[Amount]. Based on the equalization ratio of [X]%, my implied market value is \$[Amount], which is \$[Difference] above what comparable homes are actually selling for."</i>
Your Opinion of Value	<i>"Based on these comparables, my opinion of value is \$[Amount], which would put my assessed value at approximately \$[Amount × ratio]."</i>
If Questioned on Adjustments	<i>"I have accounted for [differences] in my analysis. [Comp 1] was slightly larger/smaller, which I adjusted for by [explanation]."</i>
Closing	<i>"I would respectfully request that the Board reduce my assessment to reflect the actual market evidence I have presented."</i>

■ What NOT to Say

"My neighbors pay less than me." — Irrelevant to the Board unless you have their specific assessment data.

"My Zillow estimate is lower." — Zillow estimates are not accepted as evidence.

"I can't afford these taxes." — Financial hardship is not grounds for an appeal.

"I just bought it for less." — A recent arm's-length purchase IS good evidence, but frame it as a comp.